

On the north side of the river, several battalions of ARVN airborne and infantry engaged communist troops in heavy fighting and eventually broke through into the Citadel and recaptured the airfield. Later that day, they were reinforced by more South Vietnamese troops, flown in under low clouds by Marine helicopters amid heavy mortar fire.

Despite the arrival of the US Army First Cavalry troops on the western side of the Citadel, progress in retaking the city remained painfully slow over the first few days of February. Communist resistance was much tougher than expected, and casualties mounted at an alarming rate as American GIs confronted a warren of snipers, machine-gun nests, spider holes, bunkers, and booby traps. US commanders eventually reversed their earlier decision not to bombard the city, but even then they and their ARVN allies had to fight hard. The Viet Cong base in the commercial quarter was finally taken on February 6, and the remainder of the south bank of the river over the next three days.

By then, the communists had destroyed the last bridge, forcing the Marines to cross the river in assault craft supported by helicopter gunships. More bloody fighting ensued as the Marines, Army, and ARVN attempted to dislodge the Viet Cong and NVA troops from their well-fortified positions.

The tide turned on February 21, when a break in the monsoon cloud enabled close air support from US airbases and carriers in the South China Sea. That same day, the communists were finally flushed from the Imperial palace and forced into a last stand in the Citadel's southwest corner. The handful of Viet Cong and NVA troops still inside the walls were ordered to retreat under cover of darkness. Clean-up operations continued in the new town and Citadel until February 25, when the Battle of Hue was finally over.

